both parties. Ellis was insistent that every newly arrived Company employee should learn Tamil, having recognised that here was the basic structure for all the South Indian languages. This argument, which he called his ‘Dravidian Proof’, was first set out in his introduction to his colleague Duncan Campbell’s *Grammar of the Teloogoo Language*, published in 1816.[2] What made that publication possible was Ellis’s gift to the College of a printing press together with Tamil types, enabling the first accessible Tamil grammar to be printed in 1813.[3] Other publications in Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam and Arabic followed.

Ellis died of cholera in Ramanathapuram in 1819 before his translation of the *Thirukkural* could be completed, so that only eighteen translated chapters were ever published. We will never know how much else he had already translated because after his sudden death all his papers fell, by a bizarre twist of fate, into the hands of a notorious character named Rous Peter, whose cook used them as firelighters in his kitchen (more of the appalling Peter in a later chapter).

What we do know is that Ellis greatly admired Thiruvalluvar’s work. In 1818 the EICo’s Madras Presidency suffered a severe drought, which led Ellis to order the digging of twenty-seven new wells in the worst-affected area. One of these new wells was dug in the grounds of the little Periyapalayathamman temple at Royapettah (now swallowed up into Chennai). Its surrounding wall carries a long inscription by Ellis in which he uses a couplet from the *Thirukkural* to explain his actions during the drought.

So Francis Ellis deserves his due as the first European to suggest in print that the South Indian languages had a common root that was not Sanskrit, and the first to name that common source ‘Dravidian’. His death at the age of forty-two meant that the credit went to the missionary scholar Robert Caldwell.